



CLC EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTE

Resolve the Paradox

Critical Reasoning for the SAT / Digital SAT

A Diagnostic and Practice Deck

What a Paradox Actually Is

Τι Είναι Πραγματικά ένα Παράδοξο

A paradox is not just two sentences that disagree. It's built on an assumption — that something we normally expect to be true should hold here too. The passage then shows a case where that expectation breaks down, and gives no reason why.

Ένα παράδοξο δεν είναι απλώς δύο προτάσεις που έρχονται σε αντίθεση. Βασίζεται σε μια υπόθεση — ότι κάτι που συνήθως περιμένουμε να ισχύει, θα πρέπει να ισχύει και εδώ. Το κείμενο δείχνει μια περίπτωση όπου η προσδοκία αυτή καταρρέει, χωρίς καμία εξήγηση.

1

A rule we believe

High fat intake harms the heart; more spending should improve results.

Ένας κανόνας που πιστεύουμε

Η υψηλή πρόσληψη λίπους βλάπτει την καρδιά· τα περισσότερα έξοδα θα έπρεπε να βελτιώνουν τα αποτελέσματα.

2

A case that breaks it

A group, place, or moment where the normal pattern doesn't show up.

Μια περίπτωση που τον καταρρίπτει

Μια ομάδα, τόπος ή στιγμή όπου το συνηθισμένο μοτίβο δεν εμφανίζεται.

3

Obvious reasons ruled out

The passage removes the easy explanations, so the case feels impossible.

Οι προφανείς εξηγήσεις αποκλείονται

Το κείμενο αποκλείει τις εύκολες εξηγήσεις, κάνοντας την περίπτωση να φαίνεται αδύνατη.

4

No explanation given

The passage stops there. Finding that missing piece is the task.

Δεν δίνεται εξήγηση

Το κείμενο σταματά εκεί. Η εύρεση αυτού του στοιχείου είναι η άσκηση.

Six Types of Paradox Questions

Spotting the type before you read the choices tells you what kind of missing fact to look for.

Statistical

A number moves opposite to what we'd expect.

Behavior

People act against their own interest.

Effort

More money, staff, or time goes in — the result doesn't improve.

Trend-Break

A steady pattern suddenly changes, with no clear reason.

Comparison

Two similar groups end up with very different results.

Reporting

The surprise is in how something was counted, not what happened.

How the Question Is Phrased

The wording changes, but the task never does — find the choice that lets both facts stand at once.

“Which choice, if true, most helps resolve the apparent paradox described above?”

“Which finding, if true, would most help explain the results described in the text?”

“Which choice best explains this apparent discrepancy?”

“Which choice, if true, would most help resolve the contradiction described above?”

“Which choice identifies a factor that would account for this unexpected result?”

“Which choice best explains why the researchers' prediction did not hold true?”

“Which choice most logically explains why the result occurred despite the expected pattern?”

“Which choice provides the most support for explaining this surprising data?”

“Which choice best resolves the tension between the two findings in the text?”

“Which choice, if true, would most help account for this unexpected outcome?”

“Which choice offers the most plausible explanation for the result described?”

“Which choice, if true, would least weaken the case that both findings can be true?”

Five Wrong-Answer Traps

At least two of the five choices will make the paradox feel worse, not better.



Makes it worse

Strengthens one side of the paradox instead of connecting both sides. The most common wrong answer.



Off-topic

True, but doesn't touch either side of the paradox.



Just repeats it

Restates the surprising fact without explaining it.



Only half-explains it

Fixes one side of the paradox but leaves the other side unexplained.



Gives up

Says “there is no explanation,” or argues with a fact in the passage. Never correct.

Quick-Reference Checklist

1

Is this a fact not already in the passage?

2

Does it bring both sides of the paradox together, not further apart?

3

Does it explain both halves, not just one?

4

Does it accept the passage as true, instead of arguing with it?

The choice that passes all four checks is correct.

10

Worked Examples

The French Paradox

- French adults eat almost as much butter, cream, and cheese as Americans — the main sources of saturated fat.
- Saturated fat is well linked to heart disease in decades of research.
- France's death rate from heart disease is about 40% lower than the U.S., and the gap has held steady for years.

WHAT WE'RE RECONCILING

A high-fat diet should raise heart-disease risk — yet the French, who eat that way, have far less of it.

Which choice, if true, most helps explain this discrepancy?

EXAMPLE 1 — ANSWER CHOICES

A Certain French cheeses have five times more fat than cream.

OFF-TOPIC

Both are already high-fat; doesn't touch the outcome.

B U.S. and French fat intake is now almost identical.

WORSE

Removes the one variable that could explain the gap.

C France exports more cheese to the U.S. than any other country.

OFF-TOPIC

Trade data, not health data.

D Red wine, common with French meals, reduces arterial plaque buildup.

CORRECT

A new variable that offsets the fat — resolves it.

E The French eat cream or cheese at all three meals.

WORSE

Raises fat exposure even further.

The Death-Reports Paradox

- Reported deaths jumped 30% in the first week of 2009 vs. the 10-year average.
- The spike was nationwide — no epidemic, no change in hospital capacity.
- Excess deaths were mostly among people over 65, ruling out New Year's accidents.

WHAT WE'RE RECONCILING

There is no epidemic and no clear cause — yet reported deaths jumped nationwide in a single week.

Which choice can best explain this discrepancy?

A Inheritance tax on death was abolished starting Jan 1, 2009.

CORRECT

Heirs had reason to delay reporting late-2008 deaths into January.

B Astrologers said 2009 was a good year for the soul to pass.

HALF

Doesn't explain why it clustered in week one.

C There's no reliable explanation for the anomaly.

GIVES UP

Never a correct choice.

D Chemo drug prices rose 10% starting January 2009.

OFF-TOPIC

Wrong timing — a price hike doesn't cause immediate deaths.

E An earthquake near one city reduced hospital capacity in Dec. 2008.

OFF-TOPIC

Too narrow — the spike was nationwide.

The Bed Net Paradox

- Net coverage in a malaria region jumped from 20% to over 80% in one year.
- Treated nets reliably cut malaria transmission wherever usage rises.
- Malaria infections did not fall the following year — and rose in two districts.

WHAT WE'RE RECONCILING

Higher net coverage should sharply cut malaria — yet infections stayed flat or rose.

Which choice most helps explain this result?

A Local mosquitoes had already developed resistance to the net insecticide.

CORRECT

Breaks the exact mechanism the prediction depends on.

B Many households used nets for fishing, not sleeping.

CORRECT

A second valid resolution — nets never did their job.

C The NGO also distributed nets in two non-malarial regions.

OFF-TOPIC

Unrelated regions, no bearing here.

D Coverage rose again to 90% the next year, with no improvement.

WORSE

Even higher coverage with no effect deepens the puzzle.

E Malaria rates in the region have long been unpredictable.

GIVES UP

A vague claim, not an explanation.

The School Spending Paradox

- A district nearly doubled per-pupil spending over five years.
- Class sizes fell from 28 to 19; teacher pay rose 22%; classrooms got new computers.
- Test scores fell slightly over the same five years.

WHAT WE'RE RECONCILING

Smaller classes and better-paid teachers should raise scores — yet scores fell instead.

Which choice best explains this outcome?

A A policy change tripled the share of English-language-learner students tested.

CORRECT

Shifts who's being tested — explains the drop without the investment failing.

B Neighboring districts raised teacher pay by a similar amount.

OFF-TOPIC

Other districts' pay doesn't explain this district's scores.

C Class size fell further, to 17, the next year.

WORSE

Even more investment with no gain deepens the puzzle.

D New computers were mainly used for testing, not instruction.

HALF

Explains computers only, not the salary and class-size spending.

E Score swings like this are common and often unexplainable.

GIVES UP

Not a real explanation.

The Highway Paradox

- A city widened its main highway from four lanes to eight, at \$400M.
- Models predicted a 25% drop in commute times; capacity did increase as designed.
- One year later, commute times had not improved — and were worse at rush hour.

WHAT WE'RE RECONCILING

Doubling highway capacity should cut commute times — yet times stayed the same or got worse.

Which choice most helps resolve this contradiction?

A The wider highway drew drivers who'd previously used transit or side roads.

CORRECT

Induced demand — new capacity filled with new traffic.

B Accident rates did not rise on the widened highway.

OFF-TOPIC

Safety data, not a time explanation.

C The project ran three years behind schedule.

OFF-TOPIC

A construction detail, not an outcome explanation.

D The city also raised tolls to help fund the project.

HALF

Higher tolls should cut traffic — deepens the puzzle instead.

E Regional population grew only marginally during construction.

WORSE

Removes one plausible cause of higher traffic volume.

The Vitamin Trial Paradox

- Small trials (under 200 people) found vitamin D cut respiratory infections by 30%.
- A large trial of 20,000+ people used the same dose and a stronger design.
- The large trial found no significant benefit at all.

WHAT WE'RE RECONCILING

The same supplement and dose should work in both trials — yet the large trial found no benefit at all.

Which choice most helps explain the discrepancy between the two results?

A Large-trial participants already had adequate vitamin D from sun and diet.

CORRECT

If they weren't deficient, extra vitamin D would do little.

B The large trial used an even higher dose than the small trials.

WORSE

A stronger dose with zero effect deepens the mystery.

C Some researchers worked on both the large and small trials.

OFF-TOPIC

Researcher overlap doesn't explain a biological result.

D Scientists were surprised by how different the results were.

REPEATS

Just confirms it was unexpected.

E The large trial ran twice as long as the small trials.

OFF-TOPIC

Duration alone doesn't predict a null result.

The Bookstore Paradox

- E-book sales rose every year for a decade; chain bookstore sales fell 35%.
- Analysts expected small independent stores to be hit hardest of all.
- Independent bookstore numbers instead grew about 20% over the same decade.

WHAT WE'RE RECONCILING

The shift to e-books should have hurt small physical stores most — yet independents grew instead.

Which choice most helps explain this discrepancy?

A Independents increasingly host author events and book clubs.

CORRECT

A value e-books can't replace — community and experience.

B E-book prices have fallen substantially in five years.

WORSE

Cheaper e-books should hurt independents more, not less.

C Chain stores closed hundreds of locations over the decade.

HALF

Explains the chains, not why independents specifically grew.

D The number of new titles published each year kept rising.

OFF-TOPIC

Doesn't explain the choice of sales channel.

E There's no consistent explanation for reader preferences.

GIVES UP

Denies a resolution exists.

The Crime Perception Paradox

- Violent crime fell nearly 40% over 15 years, confirmed by ER injury records.
- Yet most survey respondents believe crime has gotten worse nationally.
- That belief grew stronger even in the years crime fell fastest.

WHAT WE'RE RECONCILING

A falling crime rate should ease public worry — yet people increasingly believe crime is getting worse.

Which choice most helps explain this discrepancy?

A News and social media coverage of individual violent incidents has expanded sharply.

CORRECT

Perception tracks media exposure, not the real rate.

B Police departments improved reporting accuracy over the same period.

WORSE

More accurate falling numbers should align perception down too.

C Crime fell faster in cities than in rural areas.

HALF

A regional breakdown, not a perception explanation.

D Survey response rates have declined gradually.

OFF-TOPIC

A methods detail, not a belief explanation.

E Perception has always differed from statistics in every country.

REPEATS

Generalizes the pattern without explaining it here.

The Sleep Tracker Paradox

- 5,000 employees wore sleep trackers for two years.
- Average tracked sleep rose slightly, from 7.1 to 7.4 hours — within the healthy range.
- Self-reported daytime fatigue rose from 22% to 34% over the same two years.

WHAT WE'RE RECONCILING

More measured sleep should mean less fatigue — yet fatigue rose sharply over the same period.

Which choice most helps explain this discrepancy?

A Trackers measure time in bed only, not interruptions from phone notifications.

CORRECT

Separates duration from quality — the real driver of fatigue.

B Wearable sleep-tracker sales have grown industry-wide for a decade.

OFF-TOPIC

A market trend, not this group's fatigue.

C Average sleep duration rose again slightly the following year.

WORSE

More duration with presumably more fatigue deepens the gap.

D Tracker wearers reported higher general health awareness.

OFF-TOPIC

Doesn't explain the fatigue increase specifically.

E Fatigue naturally varies and is hard to attribute to one cause.

GIVES UP

Not a real explanation.

The Factory Automation Paradox

- A plant spent \$12M automating 65% of assembly positions.
- Wage savings were projected to cut operating costs by 18%.
- One year later, total operating costs had risen 9% instead.

WHAT WE'RE RECONCILING

Cutting labor costs through automation should lower total costs — yet total costs rose instead.

Which choice most helps explain this result?

EXAMPLE 10 — ANSWER CHOICES

A New equipment needed maintenance contracts and training costing more than the wage savings.

CORRECT

A new offsetting cost the projection didn't include.

B The plant cut an additional 10% of remaining staff after automating.

WORSE

Should have pushed costs down further, not up.

C Management expected savings for years before the project began.

OFF-TOPIC

Expectations don't explain the actual result.

D Executives were surprised costs did not fall.

REPEATS

Confirms the surprise, explains nothing.

E Automation costs are hard to project reliably in advance.

GIVES UP

A generic disclaimer, not a specific explanation.